

at a distant server owned by the ‘cloud-provider’. The biggest worry for the clients though is the reliability of storing data at a distant server and also the security of that data. While the technology is expected to be a big part of the future, currently it might have to cross a few bridges.

Currently only 4-5 per cent of servers in Indian industry have been virtualised, leaving more than 90 per cent of the market untapped. Companies are aware of the importance of the technology and hence the industry is bound to grow.

The Growth Story

According to an IDC report, virtualisation will rise dramatically by 2010. The report states that “More than 1.7 million servers will be shipped for virtualisation activities, resulting in 7.9 million logical servers. This will represent 14.6 per cent of all physical servers in 2010, compared with just 4.5 per cent of server shipments in 2005.”

Gartner projects the global market size for virtualisation to be close to \$19.2 billion by 2010. Grid computing is another aspect which Gartner thinks can be a great opportunity for Indian IT.

Currently, the big players in the server virtualisation market are VMware and Microsoft, while NetApp and EMC in storage virtualisation. Quite notably, all Fortune 100 companies use VMware software solutions. This is one industry that insiders say has not been hit by the recession. Rather, the recession is leading to more work being off-shored to India in this industry — perhaps one of the very few industries that can say so in these times.

One usually enters the industry on a particular platform, i.e. Linux, Windows or Unix.

Based on these platforms comes the need for developers in these specific fields. The developers can then again be classified as kernel developers and application developers.

Kernel developers work on the basic operating system (OS) modules. The application developers work on the user mode and user interface.

At the other end are engineers who are required for testing the software and hence the term ‘testing engineers’. The testing engineers are also divided on the basis of the OS platforms. In turn, the testing engineers have their own verticals of growth — test engineers, automation engineers, test architects etc.

From the practitioner

27-year old Divya Jain works as a software engineer with Brocade Communications Ltd. A software engineer from Pune University, he has been in the field of storage virtualisation for over four years now — a field that requires constant innovation to merge and create space.

It is a coincidence that he landed in this field. Jain says, “When I started out, I was working in the product area and I had to deal with core systems in Linux. The reason why I could enter this field is quite simply because I had studied computer sciences in my college. My very first firm was AMDOCS.”

Sometime in the middle of last year, in the immediate aftermath of the financial market crisis, his current company had laid off a few people. However now, when the US is caught in a full-blown recession, his industry is seeing more off-shore work coming in as the low-cost factor continues to play out.

Since the field is new, the technology is still being understood. The work

Face-2-Face with practitioner

“Storage virtualisation basically involves expanding storage space for data storage through adding servers. While it might sound simple, earlier what would happen is that when someone had to expand the capacity of servers they had to replace the entire server. Though now with the help of virtualisation we can simply connect one server to another without disrupting anyone’s work schedule. It is truly an interesting field to work in.”

Divya Jain
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